

rather than arbitrary or perverse” (see also Köpetz, 2017). This is so because the immediate gain is deemed more important than potential long term costs (Jessor, 1991). Although meaning can also be achieved by other significance-lending means such as notable and admired achievements, the thrill of excitement and adventure offers a more immediate solution (cf. Martin, 1999; Zimbardo & Coulombe, 2016). Taken together, we hypothesize that the search for meaning can trigger the opening to novel, varied, and intense stimulation, meaning that it can lead to sensation seeking.

Although its relation to politically or religiously motivated violence has never been empirically tested, a rich literature on sensation seeking (e.g., Zuckerman, 1969, 1979, 2007) has discussed people’s need to seek out novel and intense stimulation. For example, sensation seeking has been positively related to a variety of high-risk activities such as criminal behavior (Horvath & Zuckerman, 1993), delinquency in youth (Pérez & Torrubia, 1985), reckless driving, speeding, smoking marijuana or using other illegal drugs, as well as risky sexual behaviors (Arnett, 1998; Bradley & Wildman, 2002; Charnigo et al., 2013; Jonah, 1997; Taubman-Ben-Ari, Eherenfreund-Hager, & Prato, 2016; Zuckerman, Eysenck, & Eysenck, 1978). Sensation seeking has also been associated with a preference for high-risk sports (e.g., skydiving or rock climbing, Jack & Ronan, 1998; Zuckerman, 1983), watching fights, or actively engaging in them (Russell, 2004; Russell & Arms, 1998).

Overall, sensation seeking predicts negative risks such as drug use and criminal activities, but it also predicts positive risks such as sports, riding roller coasters, and going on blind dates (Fischer & Smith, 2004). Moreover, there is also evidence that individuals high in sensation seeking look for riskier jobs such as police officers, fire-fighters, and rescue units (Gomà-i-Freixanet, Pérez, & Torrubia, 1988; Montag & Birenbaum, 1986), showing that sensation seeking is not uniquely associated with violence. Thus, understanding how the need for novel and exciting experiences can be redirected toward prosocial endeavors appears vital to help people reach their goals without resorting to violence.

Interventions Targeting the Sensation Seeking Motive

Historically, the study of sensation seeking (Zuckerman, 1969) began with the finding that individuals react differently to sensory deprivation: some individuals need more stimulation than others to feel comfortable. Berlyne (1960, 1971) suggested a curvilinear relationship between the arousal potential of stimuli and their hedonic value: Low-arousing stimuli elicited little or no pleasurable affect; moderately arousing stimuli produced a pleasurable affective response, but beyond a maximal level of arousal, pleasantness decreases. Because optimal levels of stimulation and arousal vary among individuals (Eysenck, 1963, 1967; Gray, 1964; Zuckerman, 1969; Zuckerman, Kolin, Price, & Zoob, 1964), people differ in how much they need novel and intense stimulation to feel and function well (Zuckerman et al., 1964).

Given that sensation seeking is related to numerous unhealthy and illegal behaviors (e.g., Newcomb & McGee, 1991), prevention and intervention messages have been tailored to the needs of high sensation seekers. To this end, Palmgreen and colleagues (Palmgreen & Donohew, 2010; Palmgreen, Donohew, Lorch, Hoyle, & Stephenson, 2001) developed the SENTAR (SENsation seeking TARgeting)

model that posits that individuals high in sensation seeking prefer stimulating messages with high sensation value (Donohew, Lorch, & Palmgreen, 1991). For instance, high sensation value can involve messages that are novel, complex, intense, and involve sudden changes (Berlyne, 1960, 1971). Thus, to reach at-risk populations, that is, individuals high in sensation seeking, the content as well as the context of the messages needs to be considered. Accordingly, Palmgreen and Donohew (2010) tested high sensation value messages for health campaigns (e.g., TV public service announcements) placed in high sensation value context (dramatic, fast-paced TV content).

The effectiveness of the SENTAR approach was demonstrated for reducing behaviors such as drug use and risky sex (e.g., Palmgreen et al., 2001; Zimmerman et al., 2007). Since then, the SENTAR approach has guided several large-scale prevention and intervention programs (Palmgreen, Lorch, Stephenson, Hoyle, & Donohew, 2007). Attesting to its effectiveness, individuals high (versus low) in sensation seeking paid more attention to public service announcements in drug use prevention programs that were high (versus low) in stimulation and embedded in TV programs that were high (versus low) in sensation value (Lorch et al., 1994). Furthermore, individuals high in sensation seeking were more likely to call a helpline when presented with a stimulating (versus nonstimulating) public service announcement (Palmgreen et al., 1995). Overall, SENTAR uses communication strategies tailored to the needs of individuals inclined to engage in various risky and unhealthy behaviors.

The literature on sensation seeking also points to the importance of providing alternative means to satisfy sensation-related needs (Arnett, 1995; Roberti, 2004). One example can be found in the realm of risky sex in homosexual men whereby sensation seeking strongly correlates with the frequency of unprotected anal intercourse, which poses a great risk for HIV infection (Dudley, Rostosky, Korfhage, & Zimmerman, 2004; Kalichman, Heckman, & Kelly, 1996). Zuckerman (2007) suggested intervention programs proposing alternative forms of sexual gratification that are less risky than coital sex, such as mutual masturbation and oral sex.

With regard to drug abuse treatment programs, Zuckerman (2007) observed that the question of how life would look after drug cessation comes up regularly. Working a monotonous 9-to-5 job or settling down in a monogamous relationship is not in line with the motives of most sensation seekers. Therefore, it has been suggested that programs should offer more healthy alternatives for the expression of the sensation seeking motive that are also able to satisfy arousal related needs (Arnett, 1995; Roberti, 2004; Zuckerman, 2007).

Counteracting Political Violence by Addressing Psychological Needs

The foregoing analysis indicates that prevention and intervention messages should be tailored to address recipients’ psychological needs and provide healthier alternatives to satisfy them. Thus, if wanting to engage in political violence is indeed fueled by the desire for novel and stimulating experiences, it follows that anti-violence campaigns are more likely to be effective if they address these psychological motives. However, one observation concerning current campaigns against political violence is that they generally advocate for moderation when trying to persuade young adults not to join violent groups. As Upal (2015) observes, “most